its expected headquarters in Jaipur and a China-centric Northern Theatre Command, which will cover the entire 3,488 kms of the Line of Actual Control, starting from the heights of Ladakh to Kibithu in Arunachal Pradesh. Its headquarters are expected to be in Lucknow. The maritime theatre command will be based at Karwar, in Karnataka.

Armed forces of major military powers, including the United States, the United Kingdom, Russia, China and France all operate under theatre commands. India's plan is in line with that of the US or China. But unlike these forces, Indian theatre commanders will report to the CDS, who is also the permanent chairman of the Chiefs of Staff Committee (COSC). As per discussions, theatre commanders will assume an operational role and may not be burdened with administrative responsibilities. The respective chiefs of the army, navy and air force will be responsible for training, supply chain, logistics, discipline and other administrative affairs.

Also under discussion is whether theatre commanders will be four-star or three-star ranked officers. At present, the CDS and the three service chiefs are four-star ranked officers. Officials believe that in a hierarchy-conscious military, the service chiefs may not like to take orders from a lower-ranking theatre commander. Anticipating such issues, the Inter-Services Organisations Bill bestows powers on the commander-in-chief or any other officer heading a tri-services organisation/ theatre command to take disciplinary and administrative action against personnel under the respective laws of the three services—the Army Act, 1950; the Air Force Act, 1950 and the Navy Act, 1957.

As theatre commands will involve officers working across domains of the three services, a reworking of human resource policies is currently under way. The military has cross-posted over 100 officers from one service to another to ensure they understand how other services function.

CDS Chauhan is in regular touch with the three service chiefs to work out solutions to obstacles that they are likely to encounter in implementing this immense paradigm shift. Indeed, the armed force will have to usher in momentous changes in the way operations, logistics and application of force will be handled under theatre commands. "The start of this journey depends on right first steps being taken towards jointness and integration," Gen. Chauhan has said.

Lt Gen. Anil Ahuja (retd), a former deputy chief of Integrated Defence Staff (Policy Planning and Force Development), says that India has been a global pioneer in joint services training for decades—the NDA (National Defence Academy) trains officers of all three services, and there is a combined training programme for officers at DSSC (Defence Services Staff College), Wellington and at NDC (National Defence College). Despite this, there is inadequate understanding/ agreement between the three services over jointness. Lt Gen. Ahuja adds that current organisational structures do not lend themselves to synergised operational planning and coordinated utilisation of resources. This is because each service operates in silos defined by its own operational doctrine. "Integrated theatre commands are sought to be created to overcome these drawbacks," he says.

Lt Gen. Rakesh Sharma (retd), former adjutant general of the Indian army and a strategic analyst, believes that integrated theatre commands will be a game-changer. "It will lead to flexibility and application of concerted combat power at the sought points of contact," he says.



"THE START OF THIS JOURNEY TOWARDS THEATRE COMMANDS DEPENDS ON RIGHT FIRST STEPS BEING TAKEN TOWARDS JOINTNESS AND INTEGRATION"

GEN ANIL CHAUHAN, *Chief of Defence Staff*



"THE PROCESS MUST BE IMPLEMENTED IN A PHASED MANNER, PUTTING BUILDING BLOCKS IN PLACE, TEST-BEDDING STRUCTURES, WITH A BASE VISION AND ROADMAP"

LT GEN ANIL AHUJA, *Former deputy chief, Integrated Defence Staff*

ESTABLISHING THEATRE COMMANDS INVOLVES A PARADIGM SHIFT FOR THE MILITARY, WITH CHANGES IN THE WAY OPERATIONS, LOGISTICS AND APPLICATION OF FORCE ARE TO BE HANDLED